

EPISODE 9 (SESSION 1)

Letting Go

PRIMARY TEXT: Genesis 12–14

So often we fall into the trap of being so far away and so set apart from the people who lived the story of the Bible that we find it quite easy to think we could have handled things so much better—or wiser.

If I were Eve, I would be content...
If I were Cain, I would be grateful...
If I were Noah, I would just forgive...
If I were Abram, I would...

However, the truth of the matter is that some days, some seasons of life, it's easier than others to just let go and trust the Story.

...some days, some seasons of life, it's easier than others to just let go and trust the Story.

I'm writing this Companion message from a hospital room, sitting next to a family member who is far too young to be experiencing his new heart failure diagnosis. This may be one of those times where I'm finding it difficult, like Avram in these chapters of Genesis, to trust and wait on God's promises. I think *my* preferred timing for my loved one's return to health and the promise for a beautiful future will do just fine, thank you! But, the reminder of Episode 9 to let God do "His thing" and let go may have been well timed...

Genesis 12–14 shows us Avram learning, and being repeatedly reminded, to trust God and His story, wrestling with letting go of his plans and letting God be the author. Many times Avram stumbles through the story, yet at others he exceeds the amount of faith most individuals could muster.

He chose the impossible promise of God, and let go.

When his story began, he chose the barren wife.

When he heard the voice of a new god, THE God, he left his father's household.

He left the comfort and stability that was promised to Him by the world, following the voice of a God those around him were too distracted to hear. He went further than his father or anyone else had dared or dreamed.

He chose the impossible promise of God, and let go.

One of the greatest bits of advice I ever received about being a parent, and coincidentally this advice also came from my own parent, was to love and lead my children with open hands. I was reminded of this while thinking and praying over these passages. Avram was holding so tight to God's promises that he tried to make them happen by his own will or handle it in his "better" timing. At times he loved and led his people in fear, and when he held too tight rather than letting go in faith, chaos ensued, and others around him also felt the natural, painful consequences. There is a constant back-and-forth battle within himself that we all experience—to hold God's promises with open hands or grasp at them by any means necessary?

We're all left with this similar wrestling match at some season of life, and we have to ask ourselves the questions that Avram was faced with in one way or another.

Are you willing to keep your hands open, letting go of your back-up plans and Egyptian detours?

**Are you willing to keep
your hands open, letting
go of your back-up plans
and Egyptian detours?**

Are you ready to trust what the Story teaches us about God—that He is good? That He loves you? That He believes you are so very good and capable of blessing the world with that goodness? He's only asking you to believe it too.

PRAYER

God,

*Things don't always go the way I had planned.
Yet, I'm so grateful for each new beginning.
Thank you for calling me, for setting me apart.
For seeing all of us, in our full humanity
yet choosing to partner with us again, and again.
I may not be perfect, I may stumble and fall,
but I refuse to let my mistakes define me.
Instead, may I continue to trust the Story,
always seeking to do the next right thing.*

Amen

THE FOUR PILLARS

EPISODE 9

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the Story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

How could you meditate over these parts of Avram's story? What Text could you continue to meditate on, memorize, or dig deeper into?



COMMUNITY

In what ways does your community instill or challenge your ideas on trusting God with open hands? Of letting go and trusting the story to God? How is this more difficult or easier for other members of your community?



DISCIPLESHIP

Who in your life would benefit from the reminder that their past mistakes do not define them? Who needs the reminder to let God lead, and not try to take God's promises into their own hands? How can you model this level of trust to those around you?



WRESTLING

What questions do you have after this lesson? How could you wrestle with trusting God in our world today, even if it's the opposite of what our world is seeking? What about the lives impacted by lack of trust: Hagar and Ismael, for example? What about the "other" stories?



Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 1



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE *SPIRITUAL FORMATION*

*We believe that **if we do our part of creating space for God, He will fill it!** We want BEMA to foster practices that enable the Holy Spirit to do a work in and through us all. How does open space represent your openness to God's plan and His promises to you—not just your own plan? Where in life do you have, or could you create, space to hear or feel God calling you to trust the Story? To rely on Him and hear His voice and over the voices of this world?*

CONSIDERING CAMPUS *YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS*

*We believe **young adults are shaping the future of this world, and they need to see and hear the stories of people who refuse to let their mistakes define them.** In what ways could you come alongside young adults to model trusting the Story, of going where God calls even if it is uncomfortable? To show them how to listen, let go, and love God?*

SACRED STATION *THEOLOGY OF WORK*

*This may be about what we do at work—but it's also about those we interact with every day. Do we hold so tight to our own plans that we forget God has even better plans? Do we look for ways to bring others into the fold of our workplace or home or church so their lives can be good, along with our own, or do we compartmentalize our "work" so much that it is only about moving ourselves forward and securing our own future? Are we building our "altars" for God—or for ourselves? The way we manage employees and interact with customers or coworkers or families says a lot about the God we believe in, louder than our words or workplace policies. **The work we do every day is sacred. It matters to the Kingdom!***